FIRST 90 DAYS — BALTIMORE

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A working outline offered for discussion — it should change once I can see the actual data.

THE THESIS — BALTIMORE, AND ONLY BALTIMORE

The fastest route to a functioning region is a functioning anchor site. Attention is the scarce resource in a multi-site role, and splitting it early makes every site slower — so the first ninety days are Baltimore: present, characterized, standardized, with one corrective action proven end to end.

Fix Baltimore, and the rest of the territory becomes possible. Richmond and the remaining sites follow once Baltimore holds a defined standard without me standing in it. The exit criteria below are how we both know when that is true, rather than picking a date and hoping.

PHASE I · DAYS 1–30 · CURRENT-STATE ASSESSMENT

Observations only. No corrective action until the data set is complete.

- **Baltimore is where I am** — the default location, not a visit. Time at the bench and in sample receiving, on both shifts if the site runs them.
- Interviews at three levels: site and division management, technical and quality leadership, and the analysts and receiving staff who see the failures first.
- Retrospective review of twelve months: revenue and margin to plan, cost per sample, on-time turnaround, reanalysis and rework rate, overtime, instrument uptime, open corrective actions, accredited scope, and certified method coverage by analyst.
- **Verify the measurement system before trusting the measurements.** Turnaround especially — received-to-reported versus scheduled-to-reported is where the variance hides.
- The client view: the site's top accounts, what they actually buy, and what each would say about us if I called them.

Deliverable at 30 days: a written baseline of the laboratory as it is, with anything not yet verifiable identified as such rather than assumed.

PHASE II · DAYS 31–60 · GAP ANALYSIS AND STANDARD

- Gap analysis against a single defined standard: what the site does today versus what it needs to do consistently.
- **A weekly metric set, defined once** and small enough that site leadership can produce it without a project: backlog and aging, on-time turnaround, open corrective actions, overtime.
- A monthly management review on a fixed agenda — performance to plan, capacity, quality, people — built so it ports to the other sites later rather than being rebuilt for each one.
- **Specification before target.** Setting a target on an unharmonized measure produces reporting behavior rather than improvement — the same reason a method is qualified before its results are trended.
- **Protect what already conforms.** Where the laboratory performs, the cadence confirms it and gets out of the way. Technical authority stays with the technical leadership holding the licenses — this is an operations exercise, not a scientific one.

Deliverable at 60 days: a documented gap analysis, and a management review running on definitions everyone has agreed to.

PHASE III · DAYS 61–90 · CORRECTIVE ACTION AND PROOF

- Take the highest-cost finding from Phase I, establish root cause rather than treating the symptom, implement the correction, and define the effectiveness check. In most laboratories this is a turnaround bottleneck — often data review queued behind one or two approvers — or a reanalysis rate nobody has priced.
- **Capacity planning for 2027.** Two federal drinking-water deadlines land that year, and compliance samples arrive in the final quarters before a deadline rather than evenly. Lead and copper by 200.8 is already inside this site's certified scope, so that wave is capacity and scheduling rather than accreditation.
- A written twelve-month plan: what Baltimore needs next, when Richmond starts, and the schedule for the rest of the territory.

Deliverable at 90 days: one corrective action implemented with its effectiveness check defined, and a twelve-month plan we have agreed to.

EXIT CRITERIA — WHAT "FIXED" MEANS

Moving attention off Baltimore should be a decision against evidence, not a date on a calendar. I would propose it when:

- On-time turnaround holds at or above target for two consecutive months, on the agreed definition.
- Backlog and aging sit within defined limits, with a stable trend rather than a rescued one.
- Open corrective actions are closing faster than they open.
- **Site leadership produces the weekly metric set without me** — the real test, because it means the cadence belongs to them rather than to my presence.
- One documented improvement has passed its effectiveness check.

When those hold, my time at Baltimore drops from a default to a cadence — and that is what frees the capacity to take on the rest of the region properly.

AFTER THE FIRST NINETY DAYS

Richmond next, starting light and building — the same format, now proven rather than theoretical. Then the remaining sites on a defined schedule, with every laboratory in the territory visited and characterized by the end of year one. Baltimore stays on the weekly metric set throughout; if it has been done properly, it should not need me in the building to hold.

INPUTS I WOULD NEED

- Confirmation of which sites are in scope, and whether the P&L is cut by site, by division, or by region.
- Defined decision rights — what I can approve, and what comes to you first.
- An introduction to my finance counterpart, and access to whatever facility-level reporting already exists.
- Thirty days of questions before I propose changes.

CONTROLS I WOULD HOLD MYSELF TO

No reorganization of a functioning team before the root cause is understood. No targets on measures that are not yet agreed. No second site taken on while Baltimore is still unstable. And no trading defensible data for a faster month — a late result is recoverable, a result that does not hold up is not.